

Document 5: Minor Integumentary Injuries (Cuts and Scrapes)

Metadata

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Definition of Minor Cuts and Scrapes

- **Cuts (Lacerations):** A separation of the skin caused by a sharp object. Minor cuts only affect the superficial layers of the skin.
- **Scrapes (Abrasions):** Surface wounds caused by skin rubbing against a rough surface, scraping away the top layer of skin.

First Aid Treatment for Minor Cuts and Scrapes

Proper wound care prevents infection and promotes healing:

1. **Wash hands:** Always clean your hands before handling a wound.
2. **Stop the bleeding:** Apply gentle, direct pressure with a clean cloth or sterile bandage until bleeding stops.
3. **Clean the wound:** Rinse the wound thoroughly with clear, running tap water. Wash the area around the wound with mild soap, but avoid getting soap directly in the wound. Remove any visible dirt or debris with tweezers cleaned with alcohol.
4. **Apply ointment:** Apply a thin layer of petroleum jelly or an OTC antibiotic ointment to keep the surface moist and prevent scarring.
5. **Cover the wound:** Apply a sterile bandage or dressing. Change the bandage daily or whenever it becomes wet or dirty.

When to Seek Medical Attention for Minor Injuries

Medical evaluation is required for a cut or scrape if:

- The bleeding does not stop after 10 minutes of direct pressure.
- The cut is deep, gaping, or over a joint (may require stitches).
- The wound was caused by a dirty, rusty object or an animal bite (may require a tetanus booster or antibiotics).
- The wound shows signs of infection: increased redness, swelling, warmth, throbbing pain, or pus drainage.